

LOCOMOTIF S. PRASANNARAJAN

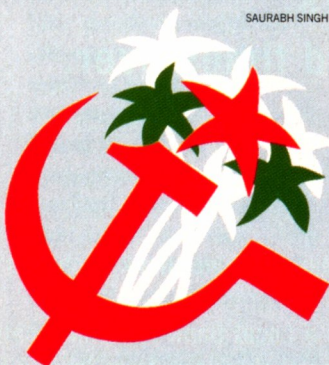
God's Own Joke



When I met E.M.S. Namboodiripad for the first and only time, it was a humid afternoon in his flat on the outskirts of Thiruvananthapuram, a few months before his death. There he was, waiting for you in an easy chair in a room whose only adorn-

ments were books and magazines, and fading little red stars still twinkling behind those power lenses. He was elsewhere, beyond the lashes of history, in the kingdom of his mind where the socialist ideal was intact, in spite of the human errors that let capitalist malignancy spread across the erstwhile Soviet bloc. In God's Own Soviet, he was the last Brahmin of Marxism, undaunted till the isolated end by the proofing mistakes in the vedic text of ideology. Such magnificent absurdity! And what poignancy of make-believe! Those images returned when the wagging fingers of an angry local apparatchik pierced my TV screen, and the accompanying shrillness in Malayalam almost shattered the windowpanes of my bedroom: communists have to change with the times; who says they should subsist on *vada* and *chai*? (Ah, the price one has to pay for catching up with news from home). Certainly, I agree with the guy, you have to break the cultural stereotype: the *bidi* smoking, subaltern comrade in tattered *dhoti*. Time for caviar and Dom Perignon, or *karimeen* and a glass of chardonnay. Or do you prefer Marx, single malt and Cohiba—not necessarily in that order? I'm with you, comrade.

Change is what we need, and let it begin with the state that had the first elected communists in power. It has already begun, and see how, and look at those agents of "refolution" (to borrow that word coined by Timothy Garton Ash to describe Eastern Europe circa 1989—revolution plus reform). We hear a lot about the party's performance in real estate (that is perfectly in tune with tradition: those soaring grayness in stone has always made man look smaller than his materialistic size); we hear about how the *Pravda* in Malayalam promotes the expensive business of progressive journalism; and we are yet to be bored with the standoff between the cheerless party boss—Lord Voldemort of Kerala communism—and the endearing cartoon chief minister—Dumbledore of the masses. In Communist Kerala, Marx is making it big in the blackmarket, and his business partners are reducing the distance between Pyongyang and Thiruvananthapuram. And there lies our hope: the scrap value of CPI(M) has gone up. Isn't it time to sell it for good, Dark Lord?



SAURABH SINGH

SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

"It is very difficult to satisfy everyone"

SINGER-ACTOR-MUSICIAN HIMESH RESHAMMIYA SPOKE to Editor PRABHU CHAWLA about his film and his future.

Q. Your film has been a hit but reviews have not been good. Why do experts criticise you?

A. The critics did not spare *Sholay* and *Hum Aapke Hain Kaun* too. I will try to win them over next time.

Q. You have accepted that you are a nasal singer.

A. Yes I have accepted it. But now more and more people have started liking my music. I have my own style and am not competing with any actor.

Q. You seemed hesitant about doing love scenes.

A. I tried to do everything naturally and the audience accepted it. No body is above the audience. I satisfied my critics with the music of the film *Banaras*. But it flopped.

Q. Are you a singer-lover or a lover-singer in Aap Ka Suroor?

A. I did the role of a true lover, that of a common man. It was the journey of a true lover.

Q. You have always been a centre of controversy and have had squabbles with Boney Kapoor, Sonu Nigam, Anu Malik and Asha Bhosle.

SUBIR HALDER

A. Asha Bhosle and Boney Kapoor have already forgiven me. I want to clear all the rumours surrounding me. I am not a *panga* king.

Q. The audience is yet to know what is behind your cap.

A. I was bald but have got hair transplant now. I will show what is behind my cap at an appropriate time. I need only your and audience's love and support.

Q. Film critics are not in your favour.

A. It is very difficult to satisfy everyone. Only Shah Rukh Khan gets both commercial and critical acclaim.

Q. Why is there no senior actor in your film?

A. We wanted a new and divine girl for this film.

Q. Where does your future lie—film or singing?

A. You will see a combination of music, singing and acting in my next three films. But I will not establish my own production house. I do not want to be a producer.

Q. Which group are you a part of in Bollywood?

A. I am not a part of any group. Many people congratulated me after the success of *Aap Ka Suroor*. The industry has always supported me and prayed for me. I want to work with all the legends.

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>

